

This is a WiP rulebook. *Text in gray italics indicates changes being considered or being playtested.*

For a video tutorial please visit: <https://arborius.online/tutorialvideo>

Arborius is a highly strategic game for two players.

There is no luck or randomness.

The game is played with collectible tiles that represent spirits of natural energy. Each tile has a direction, can be stacked or moved, and even contain a smaller game of Arborius called a **Mind**.

1. Win Condition

The goal of the game is to disable or destroy your opponent's tiles until they cannot take an action.

You win immediately if your opponent is unable to perform any action on their turn.

2. Game Materials

You will need your set of **Arborius Tiles**. Each tile has:

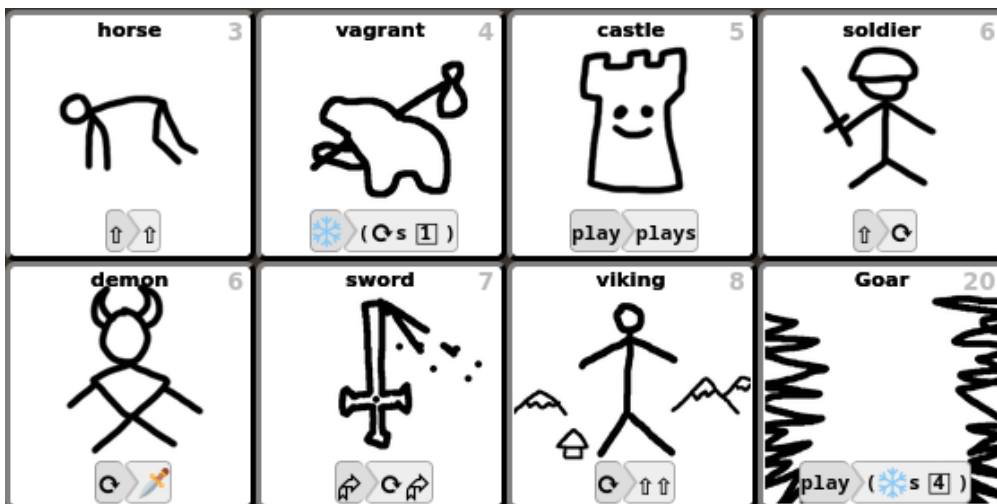
- A **name**
- A **weight**, which indicates how powerful it is
- One or more **abilities**.

Players bring armies with a total weight agreed on in advance.

Beginners should start with 50 total army weight. A heavier army will involve more tiles.

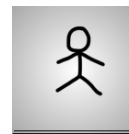
For your first game, use this simple army. In future games, see [constructing an army (WiP)] for more variable play.

1 each: horse, vagrant, castle, soldier, demon, sword, viking, Goar.



3. Starting the Game

1. Each player reveals all tiles in their army, face-up.
2. The **first player** places one tile at the center of the table, facing away from themselves.
3. The **second player** places one tile diagonally adjacent to the first, facing in the opposite direction.



From there, players take turns performing one action per turn.

4. Actions

Each turn, a player may perform **one** of the following actions:

Action:	Reference Section:
Play a tile from your army onto the table	(6) Playing and Unplaying Tiles
Unplay a tile from the table back to your army	(6) Playing and Unplaying Tiles
Move one or more tiles forward. (Ascend, Descend, Advance)	(8) Stacking and Movement
Attack with a tile.	(10) Health and Attack
Enter a Mind: Move a tile into another tile's Mind	(9) Minds and Recursion
Exit a Mind: Move a tile out of the Mind it occupies	(9) Minds and Recursion
Use an Ability of a tile you control	(11) Abilities and Triggers

If you cannot take any of these actions, you lose.

5. Tile Direction

Each tile has a **facing direction**. Tiles:

- **Can only move** in the direction they face
- **Cannot be rotated** once placed, unless by an ability

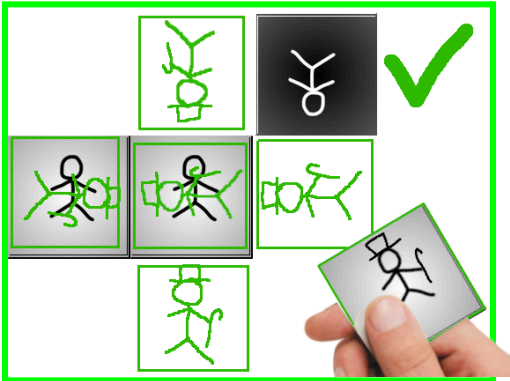
6. Playing and Unplaying Tiles

To **play** a tile:

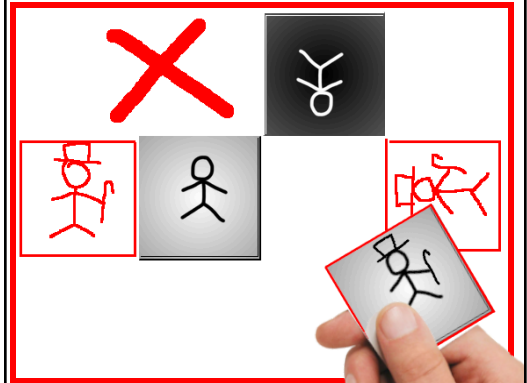
- it must be placed orthogonally adjacent to a **friendly** tile.
- It must face **toward** the adjacent friendly tile
- It *may* be placed atop another of your own tiles, so long as it follows the above rules

You may not place a tile atop an enemy tile

These are some correct locations where a tile can be placed.
Note the direction the tile is facing for each possibility.
Placing atop a tile still requires facing another friendly tile.



These are incorrect placements.
Even if touching a friendly tile, the tile must also face it.

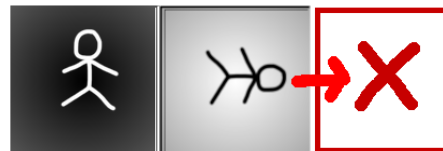
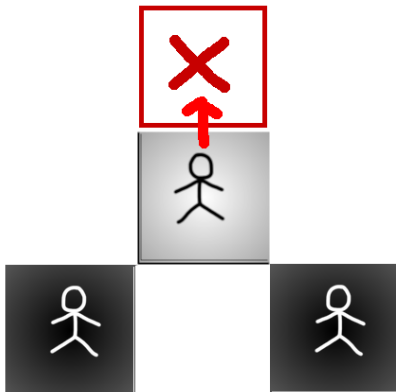


To **unplay** a tile and return it to your army:

- It must be **uncovered** (no tiles stacked on top)
- The **One Mind Rule** must not be violated (see below)

7. The One Mind Rule

Tiles must remain **connected** to a mind (adjacent or diagonal) at all times while in play (Explained in section 9. **Minds and Recursion**). Rotation does not affect connectedness. A tile **cannot be destroyed, unplayed, or moved** if doing so would split a Mind.



8. Stacking and Movement

Tiles may **stack** atop each other:

- The top tile controls the stack
- Covered tiles cannot act

Movement Types

- **Descend:** Drop down any number of tiles.
 - The moving tile's height **decreases**



- **Ascend:** Step up exactly **one** tile higher.
 - The moving tile's height **increases by exactly one**

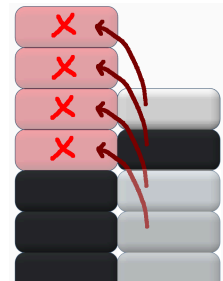
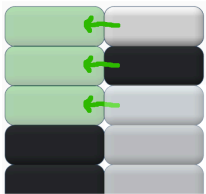


- **Advance:** Move forward one space at same height.
 - The moving tile's height **remains the same**



Stacks, or a top section of the stack, can move as a unit, possibly including enemy tiles:

- Must maintain order
- Still cannot ascend more than one level
- May descend freely just like a single tile can.



9. Minds and Recursion

Every tile can hold other tiles in its **Mind**: an internal game that behaves exactly like the main game. The main/starting game is also considered a Mind, but it is the only Mind not inside a tile.

A **Dream** of your tile is inside your tile's Mind

A **Dreamer** of your tile is the tile your tile is inside.

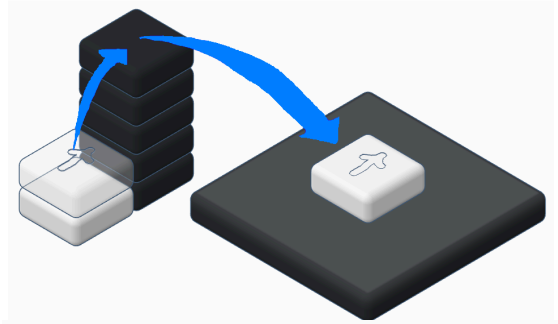
If your tile is inside another tile's Mind, your tile is being **dreamed** by that tile, and it is part of the game taking place inside it. Any tile can employ any other tile by moving it into its Mind.

To represent your tile's Mind:

- Pick an empty space on the table, mark it with a colored card to track Mind ownership.
- Place entering tiles into this new area, following all usual rules.
- This connected group of tiles represents a Mind.
- These tiles **are not in the main game**. They are inside **your tile's Mind**.
- Tiles may **Enter** or **Exit** Minds.

Entering a Mind:

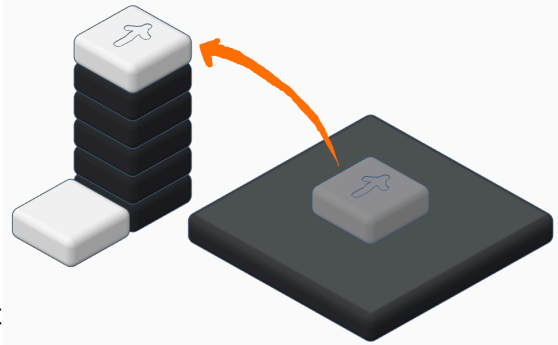
- A tile may enter the **uncovered** tile directly in front of it, regardless of height
- The tile moves into the target's Mind, becoming its **dream**



Exit a Mind:

- A tile may Exit a Mind if:
 - It is not covered
 - No stack in the Mind is taller than it

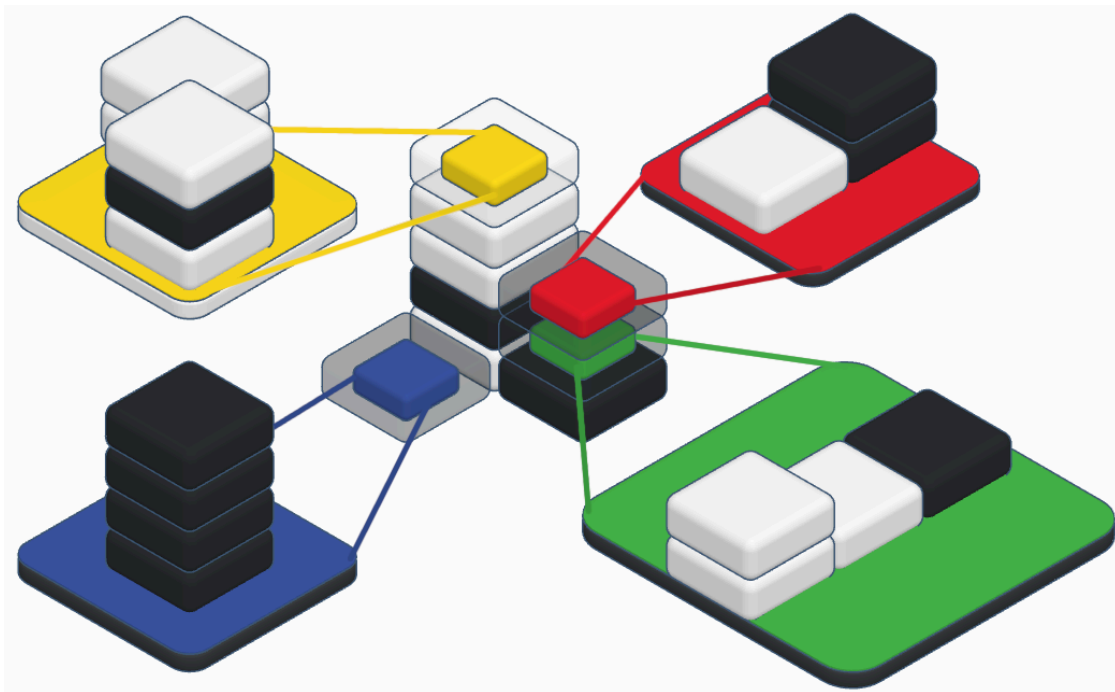
If the Dreamer is frozen or covered, all of its Dreams are also frozen/covered, so no Dream may act, including leaving or entering. A Dreamer that gets unplayed retains its Dreams but they cannot act until the Dreamer is played again.



The tile then moves atop its Dreamer.

You may not move between Minds using normal movement, you must use enter and exit actions. The position of Minds on the table relative to each other is not important.

You can also move your tiles into an enemy's Mind, but a tile will be stronger with more Dreams.



In the above image, colors are just used to indicate which Mind corresponds to which tile. In a real game, Minds usually aren't this complex and are easier to track. Tarot cards will be used in a final release to track Mind ownership.

10. Health and Attack

This section will be removed soon and replaced with a different, simpler system

A tile's combat power comes from its Mind:

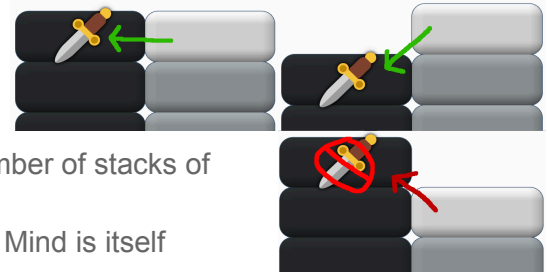
- **Health** = number of stacks in its Mind
- **Attack** = height of the tallest stack in its Mind

If a tile has an empty Mind, it has no stacks inside it.

Therefore it has 0 Health and 0 Strength, and **it cannot attack**.

Combat

- Tiles may attack the **top tile directly in front** of them.
- Attacks cannot be made sideways or diagonally.
- Tiles may not attack a tile above them.
- Upon taking damage, the defender must destroy an equal number of stacks of their choice from the defending tile's Mind.
- If an attack reduces a tile's Health to 0, the tile containing that Mind is itself destroyed. Any attack can destroy a 0 Health tile.



11. Abilities and Triggers

Use a tile's ability by reading it left to right and performing each symbol on it.

The Viking's ability is Rotate, Advance, Advance.

Note that rotating is not a basic action, so this is a particularly useful ability.

Though the rotation symbol shows only one direction, it may be rotated in either.

An ability cannot be partially activated so you cannot use this rotation without advancing.

Triggers

Think of a **trigger** as an optional "start" signal for a tile's special power.

In addition to activating a tile's ability, it can also be automatically activated with the trigger.

When your tile is affected by an action that matches your tile's trigger, you can choose to use the rest of that tile's ability.

If the Sorceress tile is ever frozen, she may also choose to freeze 3 adjacent tiles.

Also note that freezing is not a base action.

- The trigger action doesn't repeat if you choose to use the ability. (See **Example 3**)
- You can only use a tile's ability **once per turn**.

The One Thought Rule

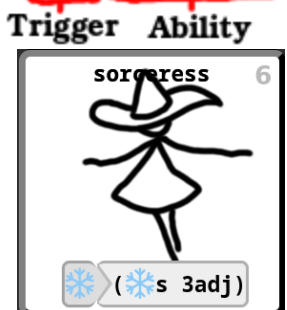
- When an ability is triggered, **all actions** in it must be carried out in order
- You may not skip or rearrange steps.

Abilities may trigger in the middle of another ability, but must be resolved before continuing.

For the Sorceress, she must freeze **exactly** 3 adjacent tiles.

If there are not enough, she cannot freeze **any**. Allies can be frozen as well as enemies.

Watch out! If you trigger an **enemy tile's ability** during your turn, you might let your opponent counterattack.



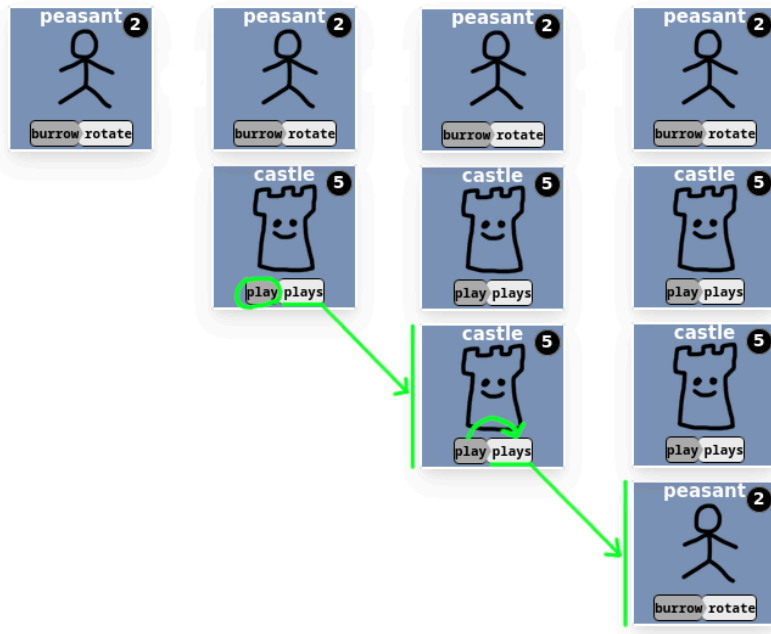
12. Examples

Example 1

If you control two Castles, you can play both in one turn - plus an extra tile from the second Castle. This all happens during the same turn.

Each column in the picture is representing a step in that turn.

'Plays' is not a global action you can do anywhere. If a tile plays another tile, then the new tile must be adjacent and facing it.



Example 2

When you play the Bastion tile, it allows you to play two additional tiles. Also, since the Bastion itself performs both plays actions, it is different from Castles working together to play two tiles.

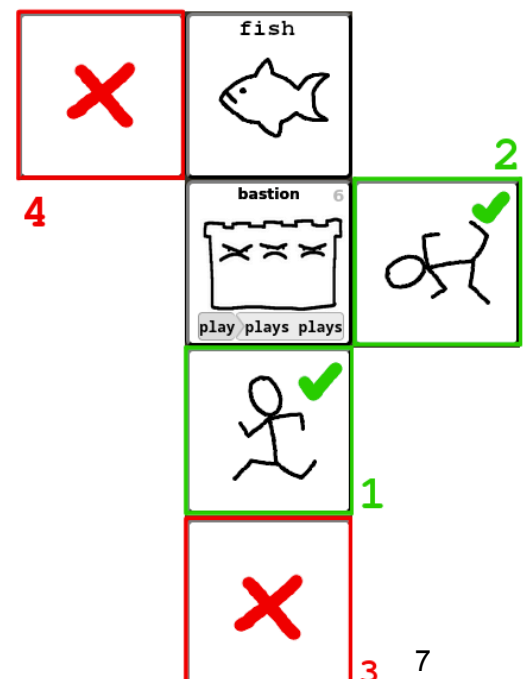
The normal placement rules still apply.

✓ Valid Placement Rules:

- **Adjacency:** Both must be placed adjacent to the **Bastion**.
- **Orientation:** Each tile must be facing the **Bastion**.

✗ Invalid Placement:

- You cannot place tiles in a straight line extending from the Bastion as in **3**, because the tile **1** would be using "plays", not the Bastion.





1

Example 3

When an ability is triggered, the tile **does not repeat** the action that caused the trigger - it just responds by resolving the rest of its ability.

In this example, the Vagrant activates its ability: "Freeze (rotates 1 adjacent)"



2

The freeze action disables the tile until the owner uses a turn to unfreeze it. Frozen tiles cannot play other tiles. (Tiles cannot be played facing a frozen tile)

The Vagrant begins by freezing itself.

- Since the snowflake symbol does not have an 's' after it, it affects the tile using the ability.



3

Then it uses the next part of its ability to rotate the Demon.

- Since the rotate symbol has an 's', it is affecting another tile.

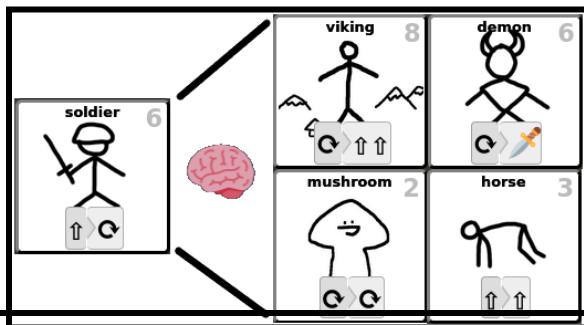
The Vagrant could rotate an enemy or allied tile if they are adjacent.



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Since the Demon was rotated, it may also use its ability to attack whatever is to the left of it.

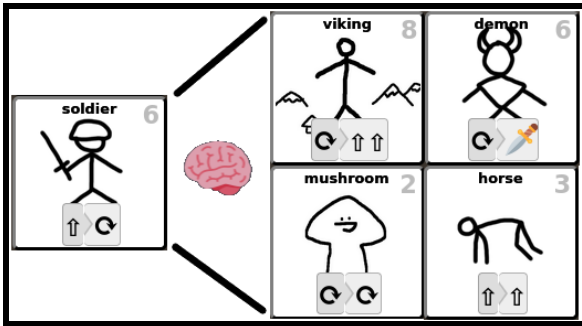
It does not rotate again when activating its ability.



Example 4

In one turn, using the *viking*→*soldier*→*demon* ability chain, the white player can attack the black tile two spaces away.

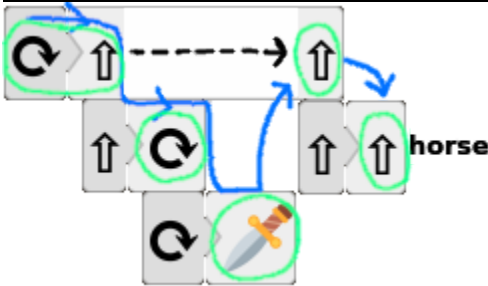




Example 5

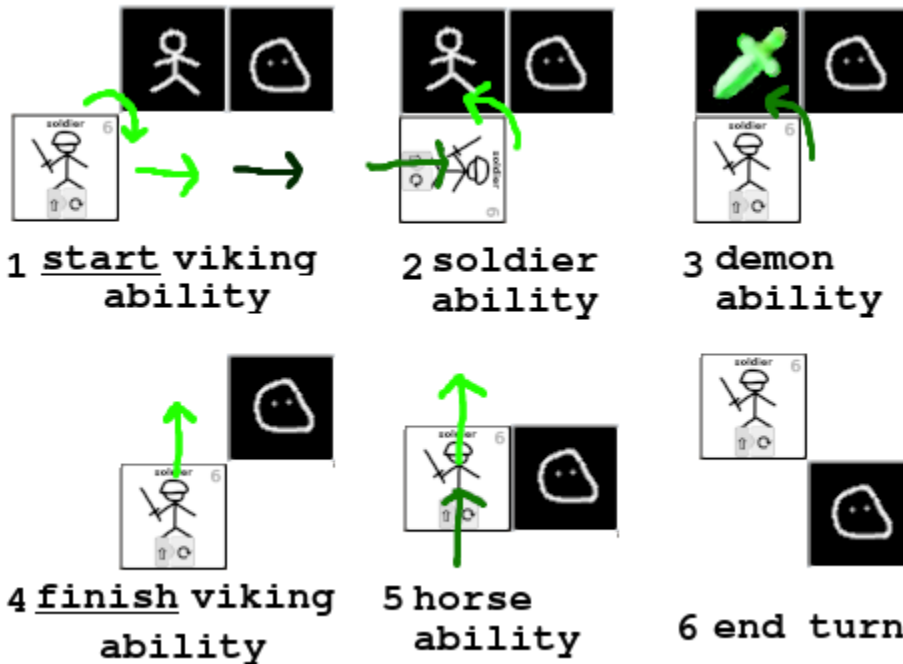
(With the same Mind setup shown previously.)

The soldier's ability can also be triggered in the middle of the viking's ability: another ability can be triggered mid-sequence, if it is resolved before returning and completing the original ability.

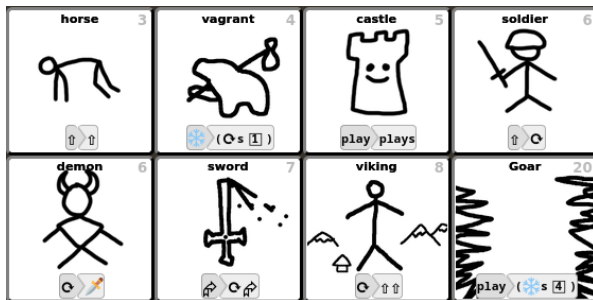


With this strategy, the *viking*→*soldier*→*demon* ability chain can use the second move action of the viking at the end, chaining into the horse's ability. Yielding a 'rotate→move→rotate→attack→move→move' chain

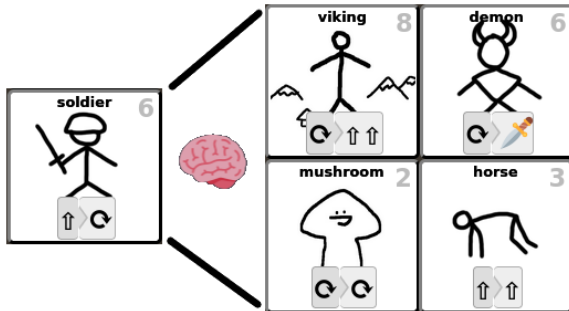
All six of these actions take place in a single turn.



13. Drafting an Army/Strategy Guide (WiP)

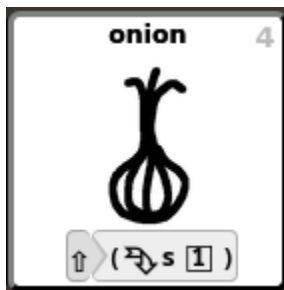


The recommended starting army is well rounded but spends too much weight on mobility and Mind depth, leaving it vulnerable to armies with tall stacks.



Assembling a powerful juggernaut tile with a strong Mind is a fun and exciting strategy, but your soldier will be short.

Remember that you can't attack upwards, so a stack of 2 tiles will immediately counter an expensive ground-level soldier that has a lot of weight invested in it.

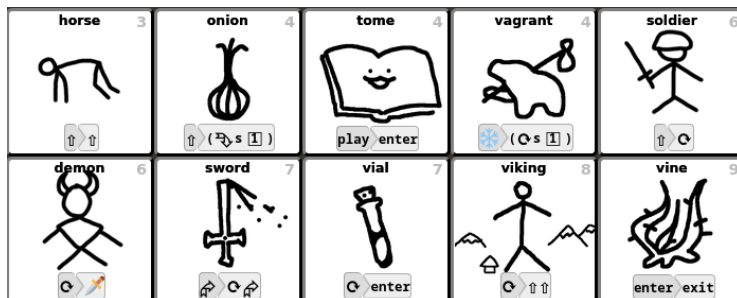
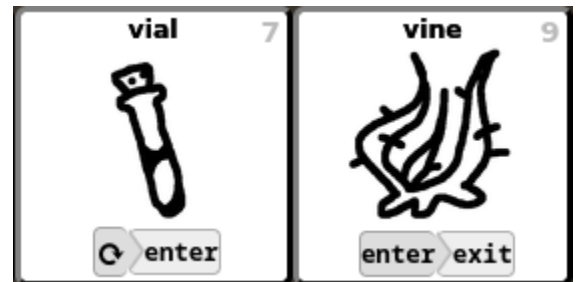


The Onion tile is an excellent addition to cover this weakness.

Not only does its trigger connect to many mobility cards, but descending adjacent pieces allows taller, threatening stacks to be forcefully dismantled.

One of the strongest two-card combos is vial+vine. These enable the soldier to apply pressure to tall stacks. If a tile does not have adequate defenses in its

Mind, the soldier will be able to climb on top of it from any height using this combo.



This is a good army for an intermediate player if you wish to extend the playstyle of the starting army.

Substituting Castle for Tome allows you to put tiles into your soldier on turn one.

Vary max army weights to yield longer playtimes:

Game Mode	Max Army Weight	Est. Tile count per player	Approx. Length
Short Skirmish	50	8	30 minutes
Tactical Mid-Length	100	15	1 hour
Tournament Match	200	30	2 hours

Rulebook Credits:

Add your name here if you would like to be credited for helping to edit the rulebook.

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Tbonesticks

Stardust

Wormius

Bo

Clixxyz

14. Glossary

Term	Symbol	Base action	Meaning
Summon	Summon	Y	
Play	Play	Y	Play a tile. Your starting tile may not activate 'play' triggered abilities
Unplay	Unplay	Y	Move a tile back into your army
Rotate		N	Rotate a tile or stack 90 degrees in either direction
Advance		Y	Move forward at same level
Ascend		Y	Step up exactly one level
Descend		Y	Drop down any number of levels
Enter	Enter	Y	Join a tile's Mind (becoming its Dream)
Exit	Exit	Y	Quit a tile's Mind (stand on top of the Dreamer)
Mind		N	A recursive sub-game within a tile. (Or the base-level game)
Stack		N	A vertical column of tiles
Health		N	Number of stacks in a tile's Mind
Attack Dmg		N	Height of the tallest stack in a tile's Mind.
Attack		Y	Attack the tile directly in front of this tile.
Trigger		N	An event that can cause an ability to activate
Freeze		N	Flip a tile over. It cannot take any action until the owner uses a turn to unfreeze it.
Burrow		N	Move a tile from the top of its stack into a lower position in its stack. (A 1-height stack cannot burrow)